Persia and Arab countries. While Indian trading communities were to be found all along these routes, Chinese traders rarely ventured out too far from the Chinese heartland. The caravan trade through Central Asia was mainly in the hands of the Sogdians, a community ethnically related to the Persians. The seaborne trade was dominated by the Arabs and by Gujarati and Tamil merchants, though Chinese vessels too sailed to South-East Asia and to the Coromandel coast. These patterns of trade were interrupted by the advent of the West, first the Portuguese then the Dutch and the British. The ancient caravan routes through Central Asia persisted, but became more localized: for example, one was between Ladakh which is now a Union Territory of India, and Kashgar in what is now Chinese Xinjiang.

The complex and shifting patterns of trade routes and commodity exchanges also became the transmission belts for religious, cultural and ideational interchange among the countries lying astride them. This is how Hinduism, and later Buddhism, spread from the subcontinent to South-East Asia. The spread of Buddhism to China took place over several centuries – through the Central Asian caravan routes, through the Tibetan plateau and through the maritime route. What this history conveys is a much more complex and varied engagement among the countries of Asia, both maritime and continental, and their links in turn with the Mediterranean world. The flow of trade as well as ideas waxed and waned through the ages as political transitions, wars and environmental changes happened. The main participants involved in these exchanges also changed over the centuries. But at no point could China claim a centrality in these exchanges.

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China is today a major trading nation accounting for about 14 per cent of global trade. In putting forward its ambitious Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), China suggests that this is reviving, in a modern context, the old Silk Road which had China as its central and nodal point. The Belt refers to the network of roads, railways, oil and gas pipelines and digital highways that China is putting in place across the Eurasian heartland. The Road refers to the maritime links connecting the east coast of China with South-East Asia,